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SETDA Response to the National Science Foundation (NSF) Request for Information on the Development of an Artificial Intelligence (AI) Action Plan (90 FR 9089, February 6, 2025)

[SETDA](#) is the leading professional association representing U.S. state and territorial educational technology leaders. We support state education agencies in advancing digital learning, strengthening technology infrastructure, and integrating artificial intelligence (AI) into education policy and practice. As NSF develops an AI Action Plan to sustain American leadership in artificial intelligence, SETDA urges thoughtful consideration of AI's role in education—ensuring responsible use to enhance teaching and learning. This aligns with Executive Order 14179, which calls for leveraging AI to “promote human flourishing, economic competitiveness, and national security.”

In response to the NSF's Request for Information, SETDA encourages the NSF and the Networking and Information Technology Research and Development National Coordination Office to ensure that the administration's AI Action plan includes the following five recommendations:

1. **Establish a Dedicated K-12 Educational Technology Grant Program** – Provide sustained federal funding to support AI-driven innovations in teaching, learning, and school operations.
2. **Expand Educator Preparation and Professional Development in AI** – Ensure educators have the knowledge, skills, and tools to integrate AI seamlessly into teaching and learning, preparing students for a technology-rich world.
3. **Support Greater Educational Technology Research and Development** – Invest in research on AI's impact in K-12 education to inform evidence-based policies and best practices.
4. **Commit to Removing Access Barriers** – Ensure universal access to AI-powered learning opportunities by closing digital divides in infrastructure, devices, and connectivity.
5. **Develop National Guidance and Technical Assistance for AI-Powered Educational Tools** – Provide clear, research-backed guidance to help states and districts navigate AI implementation responsibly.

These priorities align with [SETDA's 2025 EdTech Policy Agenda](#) and the recommendations outlined in the [Universal Connectivity Imperative Report](#) and [EdTech Quality Indicators Guide](#).

Establish a Dedicated K-12 Educational Technology Grant Program

Founded in 2001, SETDA is the principal association representing U.S. state and territorial educational technology and digital learning leaders. Through various programs and advocacy, SETDA builds member capacity and engages partners to empower the education community in leveraging technology for learning, teaching, and school operations. www.setda.org.

Federal support for state and locally driven AI education initiatives is essential to modernizing learning environments, closing digital divides, and ensuring all students have access to AI-powered opportunities. To maintain the United States's leadership in AI, SETDA urges NSF to recommend that Congress adopt a [dedicated K-12 technology grant program](#) under the next reauthorization of the Elementary and Secondary Education Act (ESEA).

A new AI-centric EdTech grant program should:

- **Provide formula-based funding to states** to flexibly support AI-integration in teaching, learning, and infrastructure, allowing for state-driven approaches that meet local needs.
- **Offer competitive grants to districts and consortia** for innovative AI-driven educational initiatives.
- **Encourage the establishment of state educational technology offices** to oversee and support AI adoption and use.

This approach will help states and school districts sustain and expand investments in technology-enabled education, ensuring that American students are prepared for the future. It also aligns with the vision outlined by Executive Order 14179 to leverage AI for national competitiveness and educational excellence.

Expand Educator Preparation and Professional Development in Digital Learning and AI

To ensure the United States remains a global leader in AI-enhanced teaching and learning, comprehensive capacity-building efforts are essential. Educators must be equipped with the skills and professional development necessary to effectively integrate AI into K-12 classrooms and curricula. SETDA supports strong federal leadership in advancing AI-focused professional development through Title II, Part A and Title IV, Part A of the Every Student Succeeds Act (ESSA), as recommended by the [Bipartisan House AI Task Force Report](#).

Specifically, SETDA recommends that the AI Action plan encourage Congress to:

- **Increase Title II, Part A funding by at least \$500 million annually, with 20% allocated to AI and educational technology professional development.**
- **Expand funding for instructional coaching programs** to sustainably train teachers in AI-assisted instruction.
- **Strengthen educator pipelines** to include AI ethics, cybersecurity, and adaptive learning technologies and assessments into teacher preparation programs.

Equipping new and veteran educators—as well as school leaders—with AI skills will enhance student learning outcomes and reinforce U.S. leadership in AI, consistent with Executive Order 14179.

Support Greater Educational Technology Research and Development

To ensure evidence-based AI implementation in education, the federal government should expand research on AI-driven instructional tools, assessment models, and ethical AI applications.

SETDA urges the NSF to incorporate the following recommendations into the AI Action Plan:

- **Increase funding for AI research in K-12 education** to study the effectiveness, risks, and benefits of AI-powered learning tools.
- **Establish a National AI in Education Research Center** to synthesize AI learning outcomes, identify best practices, and provide guidance for policymakers and educators.
- **Fund rapid-cycle AI pilot programs** to test and refine personalized learning models, AI-based tutoring systems, adaptive instructional strategies.

AI should be deployed universally and responsibly, with rigorous evaluation of its impact on K-12 education. Expanding research and development investment is essential to advancing global AI leadership, as outlined in Executive Order 14179.

Commit to Connecting all K-12 Students and Teachers to Broadband for AI

Ensuring America's leadership in AI requires equipping all students and educators with reliable, adequate, high-speed internet to access AI-powered tools. The [SETDA Universal Connectivity Imperative Report](#) highlights the urgent need for sustained broadband investment, especially in rural and high-cost areas, where access remains a challenge.

To position the United States as the preeminent global AI leader, we must also be the world's most digitally connected country. With that goal in mind, the AI Action plan should recommend:

- **Protecting and expanding the E-Rate program** to support AI-driven teaching and learning in schools and libraries.
- **Ensuring 100/20 Mbps broadband as a minimum standard** for student access, enabling seamless AI-powered instruction.
- **Establishing permanent federal funding for broadband affordability programs** to prevent connectivity gaps, especially for rural and low-income communities.

AI cannot drive learning outcomes without universal, affordable high-capacity broadband access. Making America first in broadband connectivity is a critical step toward realizing Executive Order 14179's vision for AI-driven innovation and educational excellence.

Develop National Guidance and Technical Assistance for AI-Powered Educational Tools

The Bipartisan House Task Force on Artificial Intelligence [recognizes](#) that “[s]tate education agencies and school districts often go through time- and energy intensive efforts to choose products for their school systems.” As schools adopt AI-powered tools, procurement and quality assurance frameworks must be established to help them quickly and effectively identify high-quality, trustworthy technologies that support the United States’ leadership in AI. To support this work, SETDA has developed the [EdTech Quality Indicators Guide](#) to provide guidance for evaluating AI-driven learning technologies, helping state and local leaders make sound AI policy decisions for education.

To further support responsible AI adoption in schools, the AI Action Plan should recommend:

- **Developing federal AI procurement guidelines** (not a mandate), grounded in SETDA’s five EdTech Quality Indicators and other best practices:
 1. **Safe** – AI tools must comply with the Family Educational Rights and Privacy Act (FERPA), the Children’s Online Privacy Protection Act (COPPA), and cybersecurity best practices.
 2. **Evidence-Based** – AI systems should align with tiers of evidence outlined in ESEA, as amended by ESSA.
 3. **Inclusive** – AI must be designed for and accessible to all learners, including students with disabilities.
 4. **Usable** – AI tools should integrate seamlessly into educator workflows.
 5. **Interoperable** – AI applications must align with open data standards for secure, seamless integration.
- **Providing technical assistance** to help states and districts evaluate AI vendor claims and mitigate risks related to algorithmic bias and data security.
- **Funding the development of AI safety frameworks** to prevent data misuse and discriminatory outcomes in educational settings.

SETDA stands ready to collaborate to ensure AI enhances education and promotes the country’s technological and economic leadership, consistent with Executive Order 14179’s vision.

AI has the potential to **transform education and strengthen America’s future**. Strategic federal leadership is essential to ensuring AI is **deployed responsibly and effectively** in K-12 settings.

SETDA urges the integration of these five priorities into the AI Action Plan:

1. **Establish a dedicated K-12 EdTech grant program** to sustain AI-driven learning.
2. **Support educator professional development** to equip teachers with AI skills.
3. **Increase AI education research and pilot funding** to drive evidence-based innovation.
4. **Commit to universal broadband connectivity** to support AI adoption in all communities.

5. **Develop national AI procurement and technical assistance frameworks** to ensure safe and effective AI tools in schools.

SETDA looks forward to working with the administration to harness AI's incredible educational and economic potential while safeguarding students, educators, and communities.

For further information, please contact **Ji Soo Song, SETDA's Director of Projects & Initiatives.**